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Renuka

Goddess Renuka or Mahur Renuka, also known as **Renuka Bhavani, Yellamma Devi**, is a Hindu mother goddess venerated predominantly in the South & Western Indian states of Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh.[4] She is regarded as the mother of Parashurama, the sixth avatar of the Vishnu and is considered a manifestation of the Mother Goddess or Shakti in regional devotional traditions in Hindu mythology.[5]

Renuka	
Goddess of the Fallen[1]	
The Mahur shrine of Renuka, venerated as a Shakti Pitha in Shaktism	
Devanagari	रेणुका
Sanskrit transliteration	Rēṇuka
Affiliation	Devi
Mantra	ॐ रेणुकायै विद्महे मातृरूपाय धीमहि । तन्नो देवी प्रचोदयात् ॥
Texts	Renuka Tantram[2]
Region	India
Genealogy	
Consort	Jamadagni
Children	Ṛumaṇvān, Suhotra, Vasu, Viśvāvasu, Parashurama[3]

Names

Renuka is venerated across India under various regional names, including **Aai Yellamma**, Ekvira, Yamai, Ellai Amman, Padmakshi Renuka, Ucchangi Mariamma, and Ellai Amma Mahar. Her worship spans multiple local traditions, where she is regarded as a protective mother goddess. She is worshipped in the Hindu pantheon as a goddess associated with several communities and is often regarded as the divine protector. Devotees revere her as Jagadamba (Mother of the Universe).

Legends

Legends surrounding Renuka are chronicled in Hindu scriptures such as the *Mahabharata*, *Harivamsa*, and *Bhagavata Purana*.[6]

Incarnations of Adi Parashakti

In Hindu tradition, Renuka is identified as one of four principal incarnations of Adi Parashakti (the primordial goddess):

1. Kamakshi (worshipped in Kanchi).[7]
2. Vishalakshi (venerated in Varanasi, North India).[8]
3. Renukakshi (also called Padmakshi Renuka in Konkan, notably Alibag).[4]
4. Meenakshi (revered in Madurai, South India)[9] and Bahulakshi (associated with East India).[10]

Early life

Renuka Sagara, Malaprabha River, Saundatti. (Belgaum District), North Karnataka, Karnataka

Renuka was born to King Renu after he performed a yajna (ritual fire sacrifice) to ensure peace and prosperity. Emerging from the sacrificial fire, she became her parents' cherished child. At age eight, the sage Agastya, advised her marriage to Jamadagni, when she reached maturity. Jamadagni was the son of Richika and Satyavati, who had earned divine blessings through penance. Renuka assisted Jamadagni in rituals.

Renuka's daily ritual involved bathing in the Malaprabha River with intense focus. Her spiritual power enabled her to mold sand into an unbaked pot and use a coiled serpent as a rope to carry water for her husband's oblations.

Married life

Renuka and Jamadagni had a daughter, Anjana, and five sons: Ṛumaṇvān, Suhotra, Vasu, Viśvāvasu, and Rama Bhargava (later known as Parashurama, Vishnu's sixth avatar).[11] Parashurama earned Shiva's favor through penance, receiving an axe (*parashu*), which became his namesake.[12]

One day, when Renuka went to the river, she saw a king making love to his wives. She was captivated by the sight and momentarily lost her concentration and devotion to her husband. As she was distracted, she lost her spiritual power, granted to her through her chastity, causing her to lose the water she collected. When she came back to the ashram, Jamadagni divined these events through his yogic power, and cursed her lack of devotion.[13]

After being cursed by her husband, Renuka went east and sat in the forest to meditate. In her penance, she met with the saints Eknath[14] and Joginath; and requested them to gain the mercy of her husband. They first consoled her and then instructed her to follow their advice exactly as told. They told her to purify herself, first bathing in a nearby lake, and then to worship a Shivalinga, which they had given to her. Next, she was asked to visit the nearby town and beg for rice from the houses (this ritual, called "Joga Bedodu", is still carried out by women during a particular month in Karnataka/ "Jogawa" in Marathi, "Yellamma Jogu" in Telangana).

After collecting the rice, she was to give half to the saints and cook the remaining half, adding jaggery, partaking of the cooked rice with full devotion. They said that if she performed this ritual for three days, she would be able to visit her husband on the fourth day.

Knowing the anger of Jamadagni, they warned her that she may not be fully pardoned by him and that she would have to experience the most difficult time of her life for a few minutes. "After that," they said, "you will be eternally revered and will be blessed with your husband. You will be worshipped by all the people henceforth." After blessing her thus, they disappeared. Renuka followed their instructions with devotion and worshipped the Shivalinga with reverence. On the fourth day, she went to see her husband.

Yellamma temple at Badami.

Decapitation and resurrection

Jamadagni was still furious with Renuka and ordered his elder four sons to kill his wife, but all of them refused to kill their mother. Jamadagni cursed his four sons and reduced them to ashes for disobeying his order. Then, Jamadagni called his fifth son Parashurama, who was meditating on Shiva, and ordered him to behead Renuka. Parashurama immediately obeyed his father's words and beheaded his mother with his axe. Jamadagni was pleased by Parashurama's devotion and obedience towards him.

He then offered a boon to Parushurama, who wisely asked for his mother and brothers to be brought back to life. Jamadagni was impressed by Parshuram's pragmatism and brought Renuka and her four sons back to life. Jamadagni felt strong remorse for what he had done to his beloved and compassionate wife. He then vowed not to get angered ever again and gave up *krodha* forever. However, in that happiness of bringing his mother's life back, Parashurama brings another head belonging to another lady called Yellamma. Hence she is now called Renuka Yellamma. She becomes the deity of transgender community. Parashurama's father cursed the other sons who didn't listen to him that they would lose their masculinity. Once Renuka Yellamma is brought back to life, the other sons go and seeks shelter and she protects them.

Renuka temple at Yallammagudi, Saundatti (Belgaum District). North Karnataka, Karnataka

Disappearance

According to one legend, the emperor Sahastarva wanted to marry Renuka. When Parashuram was away, Sahastarva killed Jamadagni and his four sons and then Renuka jumped in the pond known as *Ramsarover*. This lake is today venerated as Renuka Sanctuary.[15]

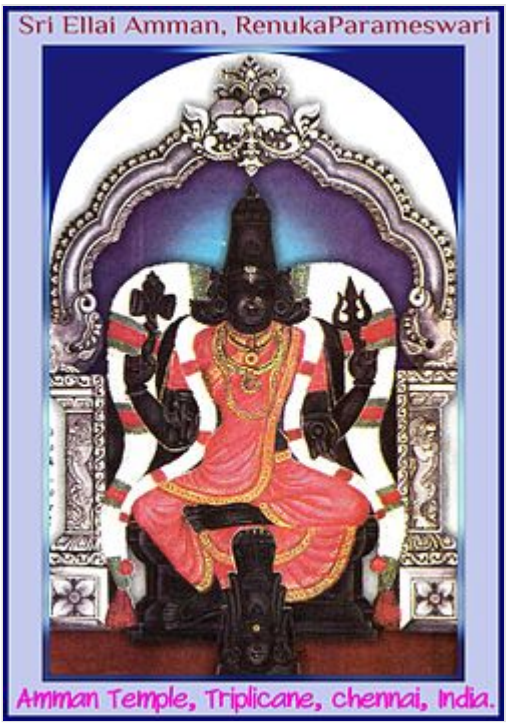
A version among Deori people states that Jamadagni asked his sons to kill Renuka to prove their obedience before bringing her back to life.[16]

Temples and related places

There is a Renuka Amba temple in Shahalibanda Banda Charminar, Hyderabad. This is a 17th century ancient temple. It is located in the Devdi of Renukadas Bhalerao,a king and the prime minister of Hyderabad during the nizam rule. It is believed that this goddess is the granter of wishes and just visiting her wards off all evil and black magic. The temple is open for public only during the 9 days of Navratri and is visited by lakhs of devotees.

One of the famous temples of Balkampet Yellamma Temple, located in the Balkampet neighbourhood of Hyderabad where every year in the Ashadha month Yellamma Kalyanothsavam is celebrated with thousands of pilgrims performing special rituals to receive the goddess's blessing. The statue of the

goddess is 10 feet deeper than the ground level. There is also a well in the Balkampet Yellamma temple complex and some devotees believe that the water in the well heals all ills. Taking a bath here is supposed to purify one of all disorders and skin diseases.[17] This holy water is called 'tirtham'. An Akhand Jyoti is also present in the temple that was lit during the renovation.



Renuka as Ellai Amman, Chennai

Every year, there is a gathering of 200,000 to 600,000 devotees at the Yellamma Gudi temple (Yellamma Temple) in Saundatti.[18][19]

Another temple Renukambe [Yellamma] is atop a hill in Chandragutti, Soraba Taluk in Shimoga. This temple is an example of ancient architecture and dates back to the Kadamba period. Another temple is in Mahur, Maharashtra, the supposed birthplace of the goddess, which finds mention in *Devi Gita*, the final chapter of Devi Bhagawatam as, "Matripura in the Sahyadri mountain; here the Devi Renuka dwells".[20]

Another temple of Devi is at Dhamnand-Posare, Taluka Khed, Maharashtra known as "Devi Yalubai".[21]

In Tamil Nadu, Renugambal Amman Temple (it is Kuladaivam for Jambu Maharishi (Jamadagini) gotra Vanniyars), Senguntha Muthaliyars and other communities' people tracing their origin in that locality. The temple is situated in Padavedu, Thiruvannamalai District and it is one of the most important Sakthi Sthalas, another temple is located at Manthangal village, Ranipet district, Tamil Nadu. The presiding deity here is called Kondi Amman (worshipped by Pokanati Reddys settled from the Carnatic-Andhra regions).[22]

Renugambal Amman Temple Padavedu, Thiruvannamalai District

Renuka Lake in Himachal Pradesh

Renuka Lake in the Renuka Sanctuary in Himachal Pradesh is named after the goddess. According to one legend, the Haihaya King Sahasrarjuna (Kartavirya Arjuna) wanted the Kamadhenu cow from Jamadagni and Renuka. So for this he killed Jamadagni, and Renuka jumped into pond here along with Jamadagni at Renuka, Sirmour (Himachal Pradesh).[15][23]

In popular culture

- Sri Renukadevi Mahathme, a Kannada film released in 1977 in which B.Saroja devi played the title role; Sri Renuka Devi(2003), another Kannada film in which Soundarya played the role of Goddess Renuka.
- The Marathi film "Jai Renuka Devi Yellamma" from 1985 is a notable full-length feature about Goddess Renuka Devi.
- The TV serial "Udho Udho Shri Renuka Yellamma" is available for streaming on Disney+ Hotstar is also about Renuka Devi, the avatar of Goddess Parvati.[24]
- For the past 40 years, Padma Shri Awardee Manjamma Jogathi has been practicing the Jogathi folk dance form. In a distinctive performance, Manjamma dances with the metal-crafted Yellamma deity positioned on her head.[25]
- The Jogappa community comprises transgender individuals devoted to serving Goddess Renuka Yellamma.[26] According to folklore, members of the Jogappa community are regarded as being spiritually wedded to the goddess. These trans women willingly devote themselves to Goddess Renuka Yellamma during their transformation, following a cultural tradition observed in different regions of Karnataka, Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh, and neighboring areas.[27] "Accompanied by the melodious tones of Chowdki and Shruthi, we sing and perform the legend of the Goddess, seeking alms. As we share the tale of the revered deity through our performance, people perceive us not only as conveyors of her spirit but also as messengers and voices sharing her life story."[28][29]
- Jogathi Nruthya, a ritualistic performance dedicated to the Goddess Yellamma, is practiced by the Jogathi community. This folk form, also known as Yellammaanata, is observed by individuals from the Devadasi and Jogathi (transgender) communities in Bidar, Kalaburagi, and Ballari. It is intricately tied to the worship of Goddess Renuka Yellamma and maintains profound connections with marginalized communities.[30] Bengaluru-born filmmaker and artist Shilpa Mudbi is currently engaged in documenting Yellammaanata, a traditional art form practiced by the Devadasi and Jogathi communities in Bidar, Kalaburagi, and Ballari.[31]

See also

- Chandragutti Renukamba Temple
- Sirsi Marikamba Temple

Further reading

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